

INFORMATION - ALLERGIES

1. Definition

Allergy, also known as hypersensitivity, is an abnormal reaction of the immune system against elements that are foreign to the body (allergens), but harmless. It can manifest itself in different parts of the body: on the skin, in the eyes, in the digestive system or in the respiratory tract. The types and intensity of symptoms vary depending on where the allergy occurs, and on a number of other factors specific to each individual. Symptoms can be as subtle as the appearance of redness on the skin, or as life-threatening as anaphylactic shock.

The main types of allergic manifestations are :

- Food allergies
- Asthma, particularly in its allergic form
- Atopic eczema
- Allergic rhinitis
- Certain forms urticaria
- Anaphylaxis

2. Causes

The substances most frequently incriminated (most frequent allergens) are :

- Airborne allergens: pollen, dust mite droppings and pet dander
- Food allergens: peanuts, cow's milk, eggs, wheat, soy, nuts, fish, etc.
- Other allergens: medicines, latex, insect (bees, wasps, bumblebees)

3. The symptoms

- **Food allergies:** red and white patches on the skinitching, swelling of the eyes, tongue and face
In the case of more severe allergies, an anaphylactic reaction may occur.

Note: symptoms generally appear within 30 minutes eating the food.

- **Asthma:** wheezing, chest tightness, difficulty breathing out and a dry cough. These symptoms occur episodically.
- **Atopic eczema:** red patches of dry, scaly skin in specific areas of the body, itching.
- **Allergic rhinitis:** in the presence of the allergen, itchy, runny nose, itchy, red eyes and sinus pressure.

- **Urticaria:** a temporary eruption of pinkish or whitish papules itching and a burning sensation.
- **Insect allergies:** red skin rashes, pain and swelling at the site of the sting, soon after being bitten. In the case of a more serious allergy, an anaphylactic reaction may occur.
- **Anaphylactic reaction:** throat tightness, difficulty breathing, rapid pulse, paleness, nausea, vomiting or diarrhea. In anaphylactic shock, blood pressure may also drop, leading loss of consciousness. Anaphylactic shock can be fatal.

4. Allergy prevention

Avoid smoking and second-hand smoke

Exclusive breastfeeding for the first 3 to 6 months of life

Delay introduction of solid foods until 6 months of age
Delay introduction of highly allergenic foods

Hypoallergenic diet during pregnancy (cow's milk, eggs, nuts)
Regular bedding cleaning in case of dust mite allergy

Air rooms frequently by opening windows, except perhaps in cases of seasonal pollen allergy.

Maintain low humidity in rooms prone to mold (bathroom)

Do not adopt pets known to cause allergies: cats, birds, etc.

5. Case management

In **case of food allergy:** stop eating the food in question for the rest of your life.

In case of **mild symptoms (allergic rhinitis)** give an antihistamine:
chlorpheniramine 4mg or promethazine cp10mg: 1x1cp/dr

For **asthma attacks:** short-acting bronchodilators such as Salbutamol, alternatively: ipratropium bromide metered dose inhaler; Hydrocortisone 100 mg IM for adults.

In the event of **recurrent asthma** symptoms: **basic treatment** with a broncho-inhaler of betamethasone 2x/d prevent recurrence of symptoms plus salbutamol metered-dose inhaler for attacks, and referral to hospital if treatment fails.

In case of **anaphylactic** shock: hydrocortisone 5mg/kg in children or 100mg IM in adults with a venous line, then refer to the district hospital.